

August 20, 2026

Cigna Healthcare
Cigna Appeals Unit
P.O. Box 188011
Chattanooga, TN 37422

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Kristie Effertz (MRN MUSC2132487), Claim MUSC-F1C0-3

Patient	Kristie Effertz (DOB 1945-03-23)
MRN	MUSC2132487
Member ID / Group	CIG607831767 / GRP-43365
Claim number	MUSC-F1C0-3
Date of service	2025-12-31
Procedure billed	CPT 99214 — Office/outpatient visit, established patient, moderate complexity
Primary diagnosis	E78.5 — Hyperlipidemia, unspecified
Denied amount	\$457.71
Denial code	CARC 50 / RARC N115 — These are non-covered services because this is not deemed a 'medical necessity' by the payer.
Appeal deadline	2026-08-07

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health is submitting this first-level appeal on behalf of patient Kristie Effertz (MRN: MUSC2132487, Member ID: CIG607831767, Group: GRP-43365) regarding the denial of claim MUSC-F1C0-3 for services rendered on December 31, 2025, by Daniel R. Okafor, MD (NPI 1558493021) at MUSC Health University Medical Center. The claim was denied on February 8, 2026, under CARC 50 ("These are non-covered services because this is not deemed a 'medical necessity' by the payer") with RARC N115, citing a Local Coverage Determination, and accompanied by the remark that "documentation submitted does not establish that the service was reasonable and necessary for the diagnosis reported." MUSC Health respectfully disagrees with this determination and requests full reversal and payment at the allowed amount of \$251.85.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Ms. Effertz is an 81-year-old female with a well-documented, longstanding history of hyperlipidemia (ICD-10 E78.5), active since August 2002, and hypertension (ICD-10 I10), active since 1963. She has been maintained on simvastatin 10 mg continuously, with medication orders documented across multiple years and an active order placed September 15, 2020. Her lipid profile, recorded in September 2019, demonstrated a total cholesterol of approximately 190 mg/dL and triglycerides of approximately 187 mg/dL, findings consistent with ongoing dyslipidemia requiring active management. The December 31, 2025 encounter was a follow-up visit for this established, chronic condition, billed appropriately as CPT 99214 — an office or outpatient visit for an established patient of moderate complexity — at place of service 22 (on-campus outpatient hospital). The secondary diagnosis of J06.9 reflects a concurrent active condition also present in the patient's problem list.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

The denial of medical necessity for a follow-up evaluation and management visit in an 81-year-old patient with decades-long, pharmacologically managed hyperlipidemia and comorbid hypertension is not supported by any reasonable clinical standard. Hyperlipidemia in a patient of this age and complexity requires periodic monitoring to assess medication efficacy, evaluate cardiovascular risk, and adjust the treatment plan as clinically indicated. CPT 99214 is appropriate for established patients presenting with conditions of moderate complexity, and the combination of active hyperlipidemia, active hypertension, and ongoing statin therapy in an elderly patient readily meets that threshold under standard evaluation and management coding guidelines.

Cigna's assertion that the documentation does not establish the service as reasonable and necessary does not account for the totality of the clinical record. The patient's active problem list, her continuous statin therapy, her documented lipid values, and her age-related cardiovascular risk collectively constitute a clear and compelling clinical rationale for a moderate-complexity follow-up visit. Furthermore, the invocation of a Local Coverage Determination under RARC N115 is inapplicable here, as LCDs are instruments of Medicare policy and do not govern commercial plan adjudication under the Cigna Healthcare Choice Plus plan covering this member through December 31, 2026.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that Cigna Healthcare reverse the denial of claim MUSC-F1C0-3 and issue payment at the previously established allowed amount of \$251.85 for CPT 99214 rendered on December 31, 2025. We are prepared to submit the complete medical record for this encounter upon request and welcome a peer-to-peer review with Dr. Okafor should Cigna's medical director wish to discuss the clinical basis for this visit. This appeal is submitted within the deadline of August 7, 2026, through Cigna's designated appeal channels as required.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC
Senior Appeals Specialist, Revenue Cycle Management

MUSC Health — Revenue Cycle / Patient Financial Services
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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record